Housekeeping COSHH and Safe Cleaning Policy

Policy BHH-HK-01 · Version 1.0 · 9 November 2026 · Applies to all housekeeping, laundry and public area cleaning staff, including agency and casual staff. Review: November 2027, or sooner if products, suppliers or the law change.

1. Purpose and scope

This policy sets out how Brandon Hall Hotel and Spa controls the risks from cleaning chemicals and other hazardous substances used by the housekeeping department, so that staff, guests and visitors are protected. It covers bedrooms, bathrooms, public areas, the laundry, the linen and chemical stores, and the housekeeping trolleys. It also covers bodily fluids and sharps found during cleaning.

2. The law and guidance

- The Control of Substances Hazardous to Health Regulations 2002 (as amended) (COSHH): assess the risks, prevent or control exposure, provide information, instruction and training, and keep controls in good order.
- The Health and Safety at Work etc. Act 1974 and the Management of Health and Safety at Work Regulations 1999: a safe place of work, risk assessment, and extra care for new and expectant mothers and young workers.
- Classification, labelling and packaging of chemicals (GB CLP): the hazard pictograms and safety data sheets supplied with every product.
- The Personal Protective Equipment at Work Regulations 1992 (as amended 2022): suitable PPE provided free, with training in its use.
- The Reporting of Injuries, Diseases and Dangerous Occurrences Regulations 2013 (RIDDOR): reporting certain injuries, occupational diseases (including some cases of dermatitis) and dangerous occurrences.
- HSE guidance: COSHH essentials for cleaning, and Managing skin exposure risks at work (HSG262).

3. Responsibilities

Who	Responsibilities
General Manager	Makes sure this policy is resourced and followed; approves the list of chemicals the hotel uses; reviews accidents and skin-health concerns.
Head of Housekeeping / housekeeping leads	Keeps the chemical register and safety data sheets up to date; makes sure a COSHH assessment exists for every product before it is used; issues and replaces PPE; trains staff and checks they follow the rules; carries out the monthly skin checks; investigates spills, accidents and near misses.
Housekeeping and laundry staff	Complete the COSHH training before using any chemical; follow the safe-use rules and the label; wear the PPE provided; report spills, accidents, damaged PPE and any skin or breathing problems straight away.
Purchasing / suppliers	Only buy products on the approved list; obtain the current safety data sheet with every new product or change of formula.

4. Approved chemicals, labels and safety data sheets

- Only chemicals on the approved list (the chemical register, Appendix A) may be used. New products are added only after a safety data sheet has been obtained and a COSHH assessment completed.
- A current safety data sheet (SDS) for every product is kept in the SDS folder in the chemical store, with a copy uploaded to HosFIRE → Documents.
- Wherever possible the hotel chooses the least hazardous product that does the job, ready-to-use or pre-measured products, and wall-mounted dilution systems, to reduce handling of concentrates.
- Every container must be labelled. Unlabelled or unidentified products are removed from use and returned to the Head of Housekeeping.

5. COSHH assessments

Each product has a written COSHH assessment (Appendix B) that records: what it is used for, its hazards (from the SDS), who could be harmed, how it is diluted and applied, the controls and PPE required, storage, first aid, spill and disposal arrangements. Assessments are reviewed every year, when a product or method changes, or after an incident. Staff must read the assessment for each product they use.

6. Safe-use rules for everyone

- Read the label before use and follow the dilution and method on the label or dispenser. More chemical does not clean better.
- Never mix chemicals or use two products on the same surface without rinsing in between (see section 8).
- Only decant into the correct labelled bottle for that product. Never use food or drink containers.
- Spray onto the cloth where possible; never spray towards your face, other people, guests or food.
- Ventilate: open the window or switch on the extractor fan when cleaning bathrooms and when using any strong product.
- Close lids immediately after use and wipe up drips straight away.
- Aerosols are flammable: keep away from heat and naked flames, and never puncture or burn them.
- Wash and dry hands after removing gloves and before eating, drinking or smoking.

7. Personal protective equipment (PPE)

Task	PPE required
General cleaning with diluted products	Disposable or reusable gloves suitable for the chemical (nitrile is the default)
Toilets, bathrooms, bins and anything soiled	Gloves; apron where splashing is likely
Diluting, decanting or handling concentrates	Chemical-resistant gloves, eye protection (goggles or safety glasses), apron
Strong toilet cleaners, descalers, limescale or drain products	Chemical-resistant gloves and eye protection
Spraying at or above head height	Eye protection
Bodily fluids and sharps	Body fluid kit: gloves, apron, absorbent, disinfectant; sharps kit and tongs for needles
Laundry chemicals (topping up or changing drums)	Only trained staff; chemical-resistant gloves and eye protection

PPE is provided free and replaced when worn or damaged. Staff check PPE before use and report any that is missing or does not fit. Gloves are not a substitute for safe working; they are the last line of defence.

8. Never mix — dangerous combinations

Never mix	Because
Bleach (sodium hypochlorite) + toilet cleaners, descalers or any acid product	Releases chlorine gas, which can cause serious lung damage
Bleach + ammonia or ammonia-based glass cleaners	Releases chloramine gas, harmful to the lungs
Bleach + other cleaners or disinfectants	Unpredictable reactions; weakens the product and can release gas
Any two products in the same bottle, bucket, toilet or sink	Always rinse with water between products

If anyone notices a strong or unusual smell, or feels dizzy, short of breath or has stinging eyes: stop, leave the room, close the door, keep others out and tell the supervisor or duty manager.

9. Storage

- All chemicals are kept in the locked, ventilated chemical (COSHH) store, which only housekeeping staff can access.
- Containers are stored upright with lids closed, at low level for heavy or corrosive products, on spill trays where possible, and away from heat, direct sunlight and food.
- Acid products and chlorine (bleach) products are stored apart. Aerosols are kept away from heat sources.
- Only the quantity needed for the shift goes on the trolley, in correctly labelled bottles. Trolleys are never left unattended in corridors or open rooms with chemicals accessible, and are returned to the store at the end of each shift.
- No chemicals are ever left in guest rooms, public toilets or other areas guests can reach.
- Linen cupboards and chemical stores are not used to store food, drink or personal belongings.

10. Spills, leaks and emergencies

- Small spill: put on gloves and eye protection, keep people away, put out a wet floor sign, absorb with paper or the spill kit, bag the waste and tell the supervisor.
- Large spill, leak or fumes: leave the area, close the door, keep others away and tell the supervisor or duty manager immediately. Do not attempt to clean up alone.
- A spill kit, eyewash and the first aid kit are kept near the chemical store. Their location is shown to every new starter.

11. First aid

Contact	Action
Eyes	Rinse immediately with clean running water or eyewash for at least 15 minutes, holding the eyelids open. Get first aid and medical advice.
Skin	Remove contaminated clothing; rinse the skin with plenty of water. Get first aid if irritation continues.
Swallowed	Do not make the person sick. Rinse the mouth with water. Get medical help (NHS 111, or 999 if the person is unwell).

Contact	Action
Breathed in	Move to fresh air and keep the person calm. Call 999 if they have difficulty breathing.

Always take the product label or the safety data sheet to the first aider, doctor or hospital. Record every incident in the accident book.

12. Skin care and health checks

- Housekeeping involves frequent wet work, which can cause dermatitis. Staff wear gloves, dry their hands thoroughly and use the after-work moisturising cream provided.
- The Head of Housekeeping (or a trained responsible person) carries out a simple skin check of each team member every month and records it (Appendix C). Anyone with redness, dryness, itching, cracking or a rash is referred for advice, and the cause is investigated.
- Staff tell their supervisor about any skin condition, asthma, allergy or breathing problem so that extra precautions can be taken.

13. Staff who need extra protection

- New and expectant mothers: a specific risk assessment is completed as soon as the hotel is told, and tasks or products changed where necessary.
- Young workers (under 18): do not handle concentrates or the most hazardous products, and are supervised until trained and competent.
- Staff with asthma, allergies or skin conditions: tasks and products reviewed with them.

14. Bodily fluids, sharps and waste

- Bodily fluids (blood, vomit, urine, faeces) are cleaned using the body fluid kit, following its instructions, while wearing gloves and an apron. Contaminated linen is bagged and labelled for separate laundering.
- Needles and sharp objects are never picked up by hand. Use the sharps kit or tongs and place in a sharps container, or call the supervisor. Never compress rubbish with hands or feet.
- Empty chemical containers are rinsed (where the label allows) and disposed of as directed by the label or supplier. Chemicals are never poured into drains other than as part of normal diluted use.

15. Guests and the public

- Wet floor signs are put out while floors are wet and removed once dry.
- Trolleys are parked so they do not block corridors or fire exits, and never left with chemicals accessible to children.
- Guest rooms are ventilated after cleaning, and no product residue is left on surfaces guests touch.

16. Laundry

- Laundry machines use automatic chemical dosing. Only trained staff change or top up chemical drums, wearing gloves and eye protection.
- Dosing lines, drums and the laundry chemical store are checked weekly for leaks, and faults are reported to maintenance and the supplier.
- Fire safety rules for the laundry (lint filters, cool-down cycles, oily linen) are in the Housekeeping Fire Safety Manual.

17. Training

- Every member of the housekeeping team completes the online Housekeeping COSHH and safe cleaning module before using any chemical, and again every 12 months. It ends with a 10-question check (pass mark 8) and a signed certificate, recorded automatically in HosFIRE → Training.
- On their first shift, the supervisor shows each new starter the chemical store, the SDS folder, the dispensers, the PPE, the spill kit, the eyewash and the body fluid and sharps kits.
- Refresher training is also given when a new product or method is introduced, or after an incident.

brandon.hospro.co.uk/hosfire-training.html?course=coshh Staff code: **999**

18. Accidents, ill health and reporting

All accidents, near misses, chemical exposures, spills and suspected work-related ill health (including skin problems) are reported to the supervisor and recorded in the accident book the same day. The duty manager decides whether the incident is reportable under RIDDOR and, if so, reports it to the HSE within the required time.

19. Monitoring and review

The Head of Housekeeping checks the chemical store, trolleys, labelling and PPE every month as part of the housekeeping audit. This policy, the chemical register and the COSHH assessments are reviewed every year and whenever products, suppliers or working methods change.

Approved by	Job title	Signature	Date

Appendix A — Chemical register (approved products)

Complete one line for every product the housekeeping and laundry teams use. Product names, suppliers and hazards must be taken from the actual label and safety data sheet. The typical product types are listed to help — delete any the hotel does not use and add any it does.

Product type	Product name and supplier	Used for	Hazards (pictograms)	Dilution	PPE	SDS on file / COSHH assessment date
Toilet cleaner / descaler (acid)						
Bleach (sodium hypochlorite)						
Bathroom cleaner / sanitiser						
Multi-surface cleaner / sanitiser						
Glass and mirror cleaner						
Floor cleaner						
Furniture polish (aerosol)						
Air freshener (aerosol)						
Carpet spotter / shampoo						
Limescale remover / kettle descaler						
Laundry detergent (auto-dosed)						
Laundry destainer / oxygen bleach						
Laundry conditioner						
Hand soap / hand sanitiser						
Body fluid / spill granules						

Appendix B — COSHH assessment form

One form per product. Keep with the safety data sheet and upload to HosFIRE → Documents.

Item	Details
Product name, supplier and SDS date	
Used for (task and area)	
How it is used (dilution, dispenser, spray / cloth / mop)	
Hazards from the SDS (pictograms and hazard statements)	
Who could be harmed (staff, guests, others) and how (skin, eyes, breathing, swallowing)	
How often and how long it is used	
Control measures (ventilation, dispenser, ready-to-use, no mixing, storage)	
PPE required	
Storage requirements	
Spill procedure	
First aid (from the SDS)	
Disposal of product and empty containers	
Health surveillance needed? (e.g. skin checks)	
Risk level after controls (low / medium / high)	
Further actions needed	
Assessed by / date	
Review date	

Appendix C — Monthly skin check record

Look at both hands, between the fingers and the wrists. Record: OK, or describe redness, dryness, itching, cracking, blisters or rash and the action taken (advice, glove change, referral).

Date	Name	Result	Details and action taken	Checked by

Appendix D — COSHH training record (paper backup)

Use only if the online module cannot be completed. The online module is the main record (HosFIRE → Training).

Name	Date	Trained by	Staff signature	Shown store, SDS, PPE, spill and body fluid kits